Understanding and Managing Work Teams

Based on OpenStax, *Organizational Behavior* (2019), print ISBN 978-1-59399-877-6, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. All stories and examples below come from the chapter.

The big idea: Aristotle said "the whole is greater than the sum of its parts." A good team creates results its members couldn't reach alone, but only if the team itself is managed, not just the individuals in it.

The chapter opens with a profile of **Eva Hartmann**, who has about 20 years in HR and founded the consulting firm Trellis. Many stories are told in the first person ("the author" below) by an HR leader whose background matches hers.

1 What makes a real team?

> EXAMPLE **The finance "working group"**
>
> Picture a publisher with a finance head in each division: adult fiction, nonfiction, young adult, and children's books. Together they form a **working group** that shares best practices. It's useful, but each person is still judged on **their own** results, under one leader.
>
> **What it shows:** a working group is not a team. In a **team**, members share leadership, are **accountable to each other**, and are judged on what they produce **together**.

A team is "people organized to function cooperatively as a group" (Katzenbach & Smith). It needs a common purpose, specific goals, complementary skills, agreement on how the work gets done, and **mutual accountability**.

Eight habits of effective teams (Katzenbach & Smith)

1. **Give the team urgency and direction.** Without a compelling reason to exist, a team "withers."
2. **Pick people for skills, not personality.** A nice person who lacks the needed skills won't help the project.
3. **Get the first meetings right.** First impressions matter for teams too.
4. **Set clear ground rules**: attendance, confidentiality, how you handle conflict. Don't rush this.
5. **Score a few quick wins** to build confidence.
6. **Keep bringing in fresh facts**, because "you don't know what you don't know."
7. **Spend lots of time together**, which builds trust.
8. **Use praise and recognition.** Eventually the team's own success becomes the best reward.

Big, complex teams: a study of 55 large teams (Gratton & Erickson) found collaboration **drops sharply as projects get complex**. What helps: executives who model collaboration, managers who mentor, a sense of community, leaders good at both tasks and people, and clear roles.

2 How teams grow up (and slide back)

> EXAMPLE **The class group project**
>
> You've probably lived this. A group assignment starts friendly and polite. Then, once the real work begins, people **compete over who's in charge**, take sides, and get frustrated. The book points out this "storming" happens a lot in coursework, and it can drag on and hold the group back.
>
> **What it shows:** conflict is a normal **stage**, not a sign the team is doomed.

Stage (Tuckman)	What it feels like
1. Forming	The **"polite stage."** Excited and friendly. Everyone looks to the leader for direction.

2. Storming	The **"win-lose stage."** Fights over leadership, people pick sides, frustration with goals and progress.
3. Norming	Things settle. Members buy into goals, agree on rules, share responsibility, and respect each other.
4. Performing	Results! The team runs itself with little management, with pride and confidence. It may become **high-performing**.

Tuckman described the four stages in 1965 and added a fifth, **Adjourning** (the team breaking up when the project ends), in 1977. The chapter's own summary wrongly gives 1977 for all of it.

Teams can slide backward. If a **new member joins**, or the boss **changes the project's scope**, the team often goes back to storming before it performs again.

The "team performance curve" (right) shows something surprising. On the way from working group to real team, performance first **dips**. The **"pseudo team"** stage performs **worse** than a plain working group. Only **real teams**, and especially **high-performing teams**, rise well above it.

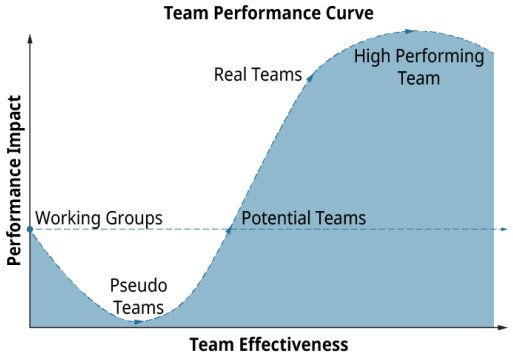


Exhibit 10.5: Team performance curve (OpenStax, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). The book names these stages only in the figure and doesn't define them.

STORY **Building a startup team: why hiring your friends is risky**

In research on startup performance, venture capitalists blamed **65% of failures on problems in the management team**. In another study, **61%** of the problems investors identified involved team issues. Founders often hire family and friends because they trust them. But research says the long-term risks outweigh the benefits: they tend to **think alike** and bring fewer new perspectives and connections.

What it shows: founders must get the **"three Rs"** right and keep them aligned. **Relationships** is who joins. **Roles** is who does what and who decides. **Rewards** is how the pie is split, short- and long-term.

3 Managing a team

STORY **The turnaround manager who didn't write it down**

A manager who had turned around several organizations said: "People have to want to work together; they have to see how to do it... and that takes time." Building the team was this manager's **top priority**, but they never wrote it down, because headquarters would have said "so what?"

What it shows: companies focus on tasks and targets, but **how people work together** is what really decides the outcome.

STORY **"Who am I managing?" Everyone.**

New managers often think their job is managing their own team. Harvard professor Linda Hill says the hardest part is actually **balancing everyone else's expectations**: the team, peers, the boss, and customers. Whenever the author started a new role, they made a **stakeholder checklist**: the boss, the boss's boss, peers, and key influencers. Then they met each one and asked:

- Whose support will I need?
- Who needs my support?
- Who could block my team?
- How will I keep influencing them?

What it shows: building relationships outside your team isn't "too political"; it's part of the job.

Three things a team manager juggles:

1. **Paradoxes.** Each member has personal goals *and* the team has shared goals, and these can clash. The manager also balances support with healthy confrontation, performance with learning, and their own authority with the team's freedom. This is the triangle of **manager, team, and individual**.
2. **Boundaries.** In a change project, some outsiders will resist out of confusion or fear of losing power. The manager acts as a **buffer**, protecting the team from distractions, and as a **bridge**, building relationships with people the team depends on.
3. **The team itself.** Pick the right people, set ground rules together, and act as a **coach**: help the team think problems through instead of solving them for it.

4 Conflict: a team's growing pains

STORY **Lencioni's chain reaction**

In *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team*, Patrick Lencioni describes a chain. If members won't admit their mistakes and weaknesses, there's **no trust**. Without trust, people **fear conflict** and offer "veiled discussions and guarded comments" instead of honest debate. Without honest debate, they never truly **commit** to the team's decisions. The unspoken disagreements don't vanish; they resurface later "in more insidious and back-channel ways."

What it shows: a team that works through conflict comes out **stronger and more trusting**, and makes better decisions.

Two tricks to make conflict useful: **Mining**: one person acts as the "miner of conflict," digging up buried disagreements. **Real-time permission**: when a debate gets uncomfortable, stop and remind everyone that this conflict is necessary. Leaders should **model** healthy conflict, not suppress it.

	Constructive (good)	Destructive (bad)
Active	Seeing the other side, creating solutions, expressing emotions, reaching out	Trying to win, showing anger, demeaning others, retaliating
Passive	Reflecting, waiting before responding, adapting	Avoiding, giving in, hiding emotions, blaming yourself

Responses to conflict (Exhibit 10.7, based on Capobianco, Davis & Kraus). The book's labels are e.g. "delay responding," "yielding," "self-criticizing."

5 Why diverse teams are smarter

STORY **The jury study**

In a 2006 study, psychologist **Samuel Sommers** (Tufts University) ran mock trials with real jurors. **Racially diverse juries** discussed a **wider range of information** than all-White juries. They considered more facts, made **fewer mistakes** remembering the evidence, and were more willing to talk about race. The surprise: this **wasn't** because the diverse members brought new information. Their **mere presence** made *everyone* more careful and open-minded.

What it shows: "Diversity jolts us into cognitive action in ways that homogeneity simply does not." Diverse teams stick to facts, catch errors, and avoid **groupthink**.

The numbers:

- In a McKinsey study of 366 companies, those in the top quarter for ethnic and racial diversity in management were **35% more likely** to beat their industry's average financial returns. For gender diversity the figure was **15%**.
- Credit Suisse found companies with **at least one woman on the board** had higher returns and faster income growth.
- BCG found diverse management teams are **more innovative**, but only when **more than 20%** of managers are women. Token diversity doesn't help.

6 Multicultural teams

STORY **Chicken feet, cheese, and 8 p.m. phone calls**

The author once led a global HR team with employees from China, India, Brazil, Hungary, the Netherlands, and the US. Calls with China meant **8 p.m. at home, 8 a.m. the next day in China**. On visits to China the author politely turned down **chicken feet**. Later they asked their Chinese colleagues which American foods *they* disliked. The answer was **cheese**, and the **giant portions of meat** Americans eat. Each year the team started its meeting with a **gift exchange** to learn about each other's cultures.

What it shows: what seems "strange" goes both ways. Good multicultural teamwork means **checking your own culture** and learning from each other. Trust is built through mutual learning, mutual understanding, and mutual teaching.

Four culture clashes that cause conflict

- **Direct vs. indirect** communication. Blunt can seem rude; indirect can seem passive-aggressive.
- **Accents and fluency.** Non-fluent members feel left out or are seen as less capable.
- **Attitudes to hierarchy.** Some people feel disrespected.
- **Decision speed.** Careful analyzers vs. quick deciders.

Four fixes, from mild to drastic

- **Adaptation**: work with or around the differences.
- **Structural intervention**: reshuffle the team to break up cliques.
- **Managerial intervention**: the manager decides. Use it sparingly.
- **Exit**: remove a member, as a last resort.

Cultural intelligence (CQ) is the skill of working well across cultures, an extension of emotional intelligence. It comes from three sources:

- **Head**: learning a culture's customs and taboos.
- **Body**: adapting your body language, eye contact, and accent.
- **Heart**: confidence and motivation to adapt.

You build CQ by broadening your mind (travel, books, friends from other cultures), practicing, watching your own reactions, and learning to see situations through more than one cultural lens.

Quick review: Chapter 10 in 8 lines

- **Team vs. working group**: shared leadership, mutual accountability, joint work products.
- **Tuckman**: forming (polite), storming (win-lose), norming, performing, plus adjourning. Teams can slide back.
- **Pseudo teams** can do worse than working groups. **Startups**: get relationships, roles, and rewards right.
- **Managing a team** = paradoxes + boundaries + the team itself. "Who am I managing?" Everyone.
- **Lencioni**: no trust → fear of conflict → no commitment. Tools: mining, real-time permission.
- **Diversity**: more facts, fewer errors, less groupthink, more innovation (the jury study; McKinsey 35% / 15%).
- **Multicultural** clashes: communication style, fluency, hierarchy, decision speed. Fixes: adapt, restructure, manager decides, exit.
- **Cultural intelligence** = head + body + heart.

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